

ANGEL ACTION · RESUSCITATION

AED — Automated External Defibrillator

An AED delivers an electric shock to restart a heart in cardiac arrest. Modern AEDs are designed for untrained bystanders — turn it on, attach the pads as shown, and follow the voice prompts.

What an AED does

An Automated External Defibrillator (AED) analyses the heart's rhythm and, if it detects a shockable rhythm (ventricular fibrillation or pulseless ventricular tachycardia), it delivers a controlled electric shock to try to restart a normal heartbeat.

How to use an AED

1. **Turn it on.** Open the lid or press the power button.
2. **Attach the pads** to the person's bare chest as shown on the pad packaging:
 - **Adult:** one pad below the right collarbone, one pad on the left side below the armpit.
 - **Child under 8 or under 25 kg:** use paediatric pads if available — one on the centre of the chest, one on the middle of the back.
1. **Stand clear** while the AED analyses the heart rhythm.
2. **Deliver the shock** if instructed — make sure no one is touching the person, then press the flashing button.
3. **Resume CPR immediately** after the shock or if no shock is advised. The AED will re-analyse every 2 minutes.

Special situations

- **Wet skin or rain:** dry the chest quickly and continue. Move away from puddles.
- **Hairy chest:** pads must contact skin — shave or pull off pads quickly if needed (most kits include a razor).
- **Implanted pacemaker:** place the pad at least 8 cm away from any visible lump.
- **Medication patches:** remove and wipe the area before placing the pad.

Finding an AED

Use the **GoodSAM AED Finder** or call **000** — the operator can direct you to the nearest registered AED.

See also

An AED is step **D** of **DRSABCD**. Keep doing **CPR** while the device is being collected and attached.

Adapted from Australian First Aid 5th Edition. Get the full guide and live CPR metronome at firstaidangel.org.